

Treading with caution: Serena Williams would have likely paired her weight-loss medication post pregnancy with her usual regimen of workouts and a carefully structured diet. REUTERS

loss by reducing hunger, making them an effective treatment for individuals with obesity or metabolic disorders.

However, the question remains: should athletes use these drugs? And what does it mean for the integrity of sport and overall health?

I have been asked about this topic repeatedly, especially in light of recent stories such as Serena Williams' use of Ozempic after her pregnancy. Serena, who has always stood for defiance and overcoming personal obstacles, reportedly used the drug to lose a significant amount of weight. This sparked both appreciation and criticism. As a nutritionist, I think it's important to provide clarity about the real implications of using such drugs.

The Ozempic appeal

Ozempic is a GLP-1 agonist that helps control blood sugar and appetite by mimicking a hormone in the body. When used appropriately, it can result in weight loss by reducing hunger, which often leads to eating less. However, while it has been proven effective in helping those who struggle with obesity and metabolic issues, its rise in popularity among celebrities and athletes has caused concern.

I completely understand why someone like Serena Williams might use a drug like Ozempic. After pregnancy, many women face significant challenges when it comes to shedding weight. Pregnancy can alter one's metabolism, and the physical toll of childbirth is often underestimated. I believe Serena, like many others, may have sought medical assistance to help her manage these changes and regain her fitness. But the problem arises when these drugs are marketed as a quick fix, without clear discussions around the potential risks and necessary lifestyle changes.

Importance of medical oversight

From my perspective, the use of any drug, especially one like Ozempic, needs to be medically supervised. It's not something that should be taken lightly. These drugs are prescribed for medical conditions like diabetes and obesity, conditions that, if left untreated, can lead to serious health complications such as heart disease, stroke, and even premature death. For an athlete like Serena, whose health and fitness are her livelihood, the decision to take Ozempic may be a medical one, guided by her doctors and nutritionists.

However, I think it's important for the general public to understand that weight loss medications should never be viewed as a simple solution for vanity or appearance. We have to approach them as part of a broader, medically informed strategy. Athletes, or anyone for that matter, must remember that medications alone will not create lasting health or fitness. It's the combination of medication, proper exercise, and nutrition that will ensure long-term success.

Need for exercise and nutrition

While Ozempic can reduce appetite and support weight loss, it does not replace the need for proper nutrition or exercise. In fact, when people lose weight using this medication, they may also lose muscle mass, which can be detrimental for any athlete. For instance, studies have shown that a significant portion of the weight lost while using GLP-1 medications can come from muscle tissue.

That's why I always emphasise the need for an integrated approach. If you're losing weight with medication like Ozempic, you still need to maintain a balanced diet that provides essential nutrients. Exercise is crucial as well. When we work with athletes, we focus on building lean muscle and improving overall fitness. Without exercise, the weight lost can lead to negative outcomes such as decreased muscle mass and even bone density loss. For someone like Serena Williams, who is no stranger to intense training and conditioning, it's likely that she paired her medication with her usual regimen of workouts

and a carefully structured diet. But many people overlook the fact that they need to eat well and exercise in tandem with using these medications.

Are these appropriate for athletes?

Now, we have to ask: should athletes be using drugs like Ozempic? While I understand the appeal of a quick solution, I am very cautious about recommending such drugs in the world of professional sport. In many disciplines, athletes rely on strength, endurance, and muscle mass to perform. If athletes use a weight loss drug and lose a substantial amount of muscle, it could hinder their performance.

In my opinion, athletes using a weight loss drug should be under the strict supervision of their healthcare team. And those who are using it solely for vanity, or to conform to societal standards, may not fully appreciate the long-term consequences for their health.

Nuanced understanding required

The rise of weight loss drugs like Ozempic has opened up new possibilities for individuals struggling with obesity and metabolic disorders. However, for athletes, I believe it's crucial to understand the full implications of using such medications. Drugs like Ozempic can help with weight loss, but they should not replace a well-rounded approach to health, which includes proper nutrition, exercise, and mental wellness. Once again, remember: only your doctor can prescribe medications like Ozempic, as they are best equipped to assess your health and determine what's right for you. Always consult with a healthcare professional before considering any treatment.

As a nutritionist, I urge athletes to focus on sustainable lifestyle changes that will lead to long-term success. Quick fixes like weight loss drugs may offer temporary results, but it's the holistic approach to health that will ensure both athletic performance and overall well-being for years to come. Athletes, especially in competitive sport, need to understand that their bodies are their most valuable asset and should be treated as such.